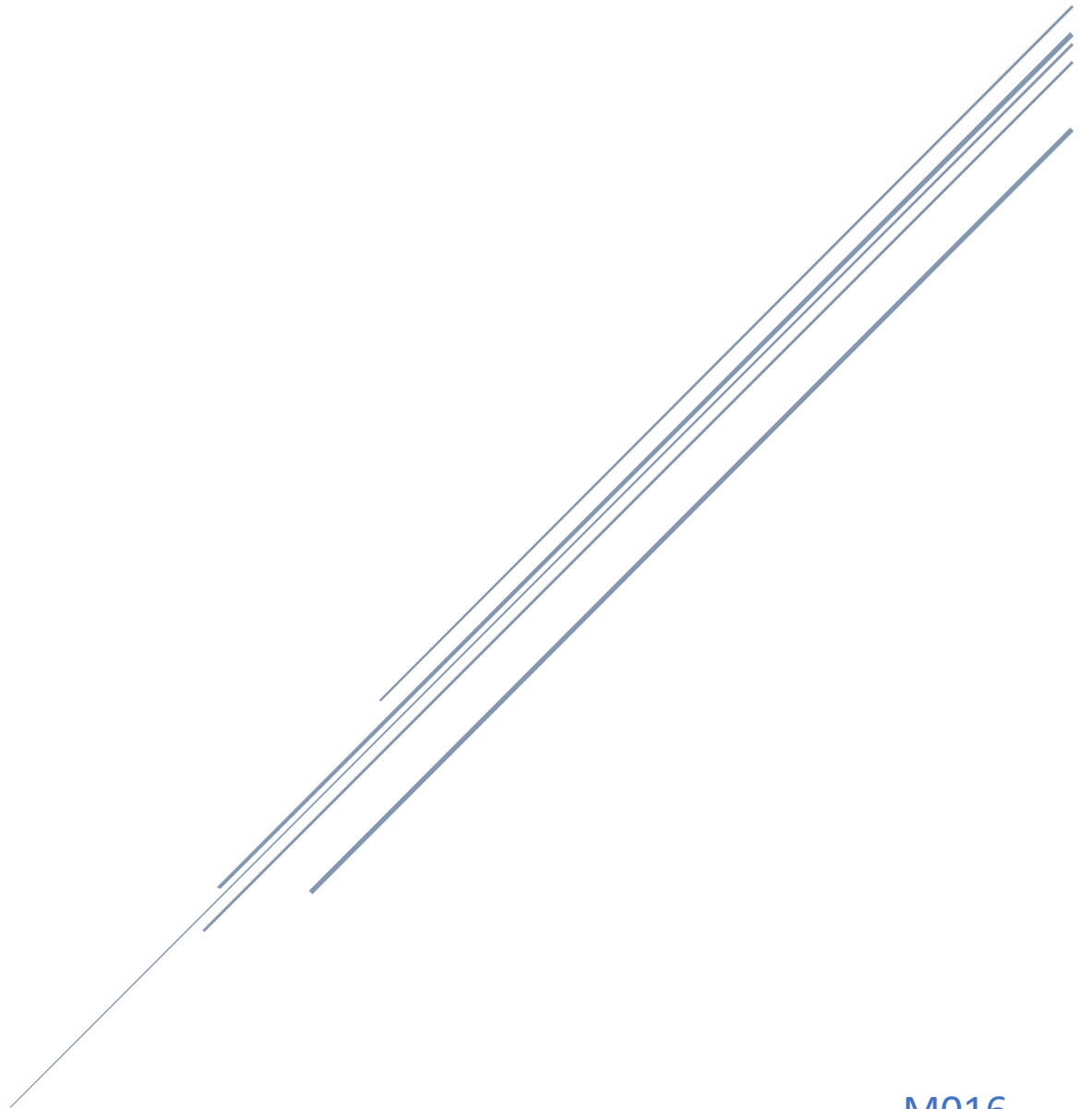


EXPLORING THE INTERPLAY OF AGE IN ROMANTIC RELATIONSHIPS: DYNAMICS, SATISFACTION, AND LONGEVITY



Yitian Li·

Paul Bedu-Osei Jr·

Mingrui Qi·

M016
Lejia Du

INTRODUCTION

People in different age groups have different viewpoints and experiences. How they will behave in romantic relationships are also different. As a result, romantic relationships at different ages may have different relationship dynamics and outcomes. However, we still know very little about how age specifically affects romantic relationships and what the consequences can be. Therefore, this brings up the crucial research question: How does the age of individuals in a romantic relationship impact its dynamics, satisfaction, and longevity? The aim of our study was to investigate whether age differences in individuals in romantic relationships affect their dynamics, satisfaction, and longevity. College students may benefit much from this survey since they are at the intersection of youth and adulthood and frequently encounter a range of relationship experiences. If they know whether age difference will affect dynamics, satisfaction, and longevity in romantic relationships, it will improve stability and quality of their future romantic relationships.

Couples with significant age differences had similar levels of relationship satisfaction compared to couples with little or no age differences. Their relationship satisfaction was more influenced by relationship dynamics, such as perceived relationship fairness and social support, than by the age difference itself. A 2008 study by Lehmiller and Christopher found that couples with larger age gaps experience more social opposition. This opposition is hard to ignore and may affect the relationship commitment of couples with larger age gaps during the year. This result is consistent with the "Romeo and Juliet" effect. It notes that greater opposition is associated with greater commitment, which may be in the form of resistance to social norms or prejudices (Lehmiller & Christopher, 2008). Factors related to relationship dynamics, such as the quality of online interactions, are also critical in determining relationship satisfaction. This may

be more important than age differences between couples. The study found that aspects of online relationship quality, such as online intimacy, positively influenced romantic relationship satisfaction, while factors like cyberdating and emotional communication strategies had a negative impact on romantic relationships (Sánchez et al., 2017).

METHOD

Design and the Participants

In our investigation of the proposed model, a correlational design was employed within a sample of approximately 1200 PSY 205 students at Syracuse University in Syracuse, New York. The participants, primarily enrolled in the PSY 205 course, form a diverse cohort representing various demographic backgrounds and educational levels.

To refine the precision of our study, we strategically stratified the student population into two distinct groups. The first group consists of couples with different educational levels, while the second comprises couples with the same educational levels. This intentional stratification serves a dual purpose: it controls for extraneous variables related to educational levels and considers potential influences of past experiences throughout the course of the experiment.

The stratification not only enhances the accuracy of our findings but also facilitates a comparative assessment of the effects of age on dynamics, satisfaction, and longevity. Couples with the same educational level often share similar ages (1-2 age differences), whereas those with different educational levels may exhibit age gaps (4-5 age differences) and some others with a moderate age gap, typically around 3 years. The ages of students are also checked and considered in the stratification for more accuracy.

Ethical considerations were of paramount importance throughout the study, with participants providing informed consent to ensure the ethical conduct of our research. This

comprehensive approach allows us to explore and analyze the nuanced relationships within the diverse landscape of PSY 205 students, shedding light on the intricate interplay of age on dynamics, satisfaction, and longevity.

Participants would have the choice to participate to earn a mandatory PIR (Participation in research) credits for the PSY 205 class. And in investigating the influence of age on romantic relationship dynamics, satisfaction, and longevity, a cross-sectional survey emerges as a pragmatic and efficient choice as this approach aligns with the real-world dynamics of romantic relationships, where factors such as age can exert influence at any given moment.

The exclusion criterion was non-Syracuse students as the SONA system was used as it is restricted to the only SU students.

Measures

This research received approval from the university's Institutional Review Board (IRB). Utilizing the SONA system, students were provided the option to participate in the survey alongside their romantic partners. Upon expressing interest and meeting eligibility criteria, participants over the age of 18 received a comprehensive explanation of the procedures, with particular emphasis on informed consent. The research team employed an anonymous Computer Assisted Self Interview (CASI) to enhance data sensitivity, reduce missing data, transcription errors, and alleviate participant burden, as suggested by previous studies (Jones, 2003; Morrison-Beedy, Carey, & Tu, 2006). Couples were instructed to respond to survey questions based on their relationship with their main partner. Following the completion of the survey, couples, particularly those enrolled in PSY 205, were duly appreciated for their time, and appropriately credited through the SONA system online.

A cross-sectional survey was used as this design facilitates the collection of data from a diverse population at a single point in time, allowing for a comprehensive snapshot of the current state of romantic relationships across various age groups. The survey's efficiency proves crucial for exploring age-related patterns within relationships, providing valuable insights without the need for extensive longitudinal commitments from participants.

Procedure

Prior to commencing our study, we secured approval from the university's Institutional Review Board (IRB) to uphold ethical standards, safeguard participants' rights, and ensure their well-being. To facilitate the stratification of couples from distinct educational backgrounds, often characterized by significant age differences, we implemented a systematic approach. This involved having these couples complete the same survey but with a distinct labeling for straightforward comparison and assessment.

Upon arrival, participating couples met with one of the experimenters to register their names, qualifying them for the credits they would earn. Afterward, they moved to an assigned room to interact with a meticulously designed survey instrument covering essential variables such as relationship dynamics, satisfaction, and longevity. Additionally, another set of questions focused on the same stuff but included age gaps, specifically pertaining to their experiences in past romantic relationships for better comparison and understanding. Clear instructions were given to respond to survey questions based on their unique relationship dynamics.

Upon completion of the survey, our team expressed gratitude to all participants, extending a special acknowledgment to those enrolled in PSY 205, for their invaluable time and contributions to the study. Participants were ensured appropriate credits or incentives through the SONA system as a token of appreciation for their participation.

Data Analysis Plan

This research will scrutinize responses from surveys completed by couples with the same and different education levels, with a particular focus on the age gap within the romantic relationship. To evaluate the influence of age on relationship dynamics, satisfaction, and longevity, coders from the research team will meticulously clean and prepare the data, addressing missing entries, outliers, and inconsistencies. Subsequently, a comprehensive data analysis will be conducted to determine and compare which group of couples—those with the same education level or those with different education levels—exhibit positive trends in relationship dynamics, satisfaction, and longevity. Furthermore, the study aims to compare participants' current and past relationships, shedding light on how relationship dynamics, satisfaction, and longevity come into play concerning the age gap within couples.

The research did not uncover a significant correlation between the extent of the age gap and relationship satisfaction. This implies that the age difference between partners is not a dependable predictor of individuals' satisfaction levels in their romantic relationships. In alignment with Rusbult's (1980) investment model, the study highlights satisfaction as the primary influencer of commitment in relationships, underscoring its central role in the success of a relationship, regardless of the age gap.

Given this, the study is crafted to investigate how cultural and socio-economic factors, in conjunction with different types of romantic relationships (heterosexual vs. LGBTQ+), moderate the impact of age on the dynamics, satisfaction, and longevity of romantic relationships. This research aims to bridge existing gaps by encompassing a diverse sample that spans various cultural backgrounds and socio-economic statuses and includes representation from both heterosexual and LGBTQ+ relationships.

Conclusion

This research focuses on the age gap in romantic relationships and the impact of age on relationship dynamics, satisfaction, and longevity. After studying couples with the same and different levels of education based on their age gaps. The study did not find a significant link between the degree of age gap and romantic relationships, which also represents the fact that the degree of age gap between lovers is unlikely to reliably predict an individual's level of satisfaction in a romantic relationship, consistent with Rusbult's (1980) model of investment. In essence, when there is love, authenticity, and mutual understanding between adults and college students, the relationship can flourish despite societal stigmas and cultural norms. If both individuals in the relationship feel at ease, it can thrive just like couples with age gaps deemed acceptable by society. As depicted in the hypothesized figures—Figure 1, Figure 2, and Figure 3—we observe that satisfaction, longevity, and dynamics are comparable to those in relationships with conventional age differences. Consequently, such relationships do not inherently impact the satisfaction, longevity, and dynamics of a romantic connection.

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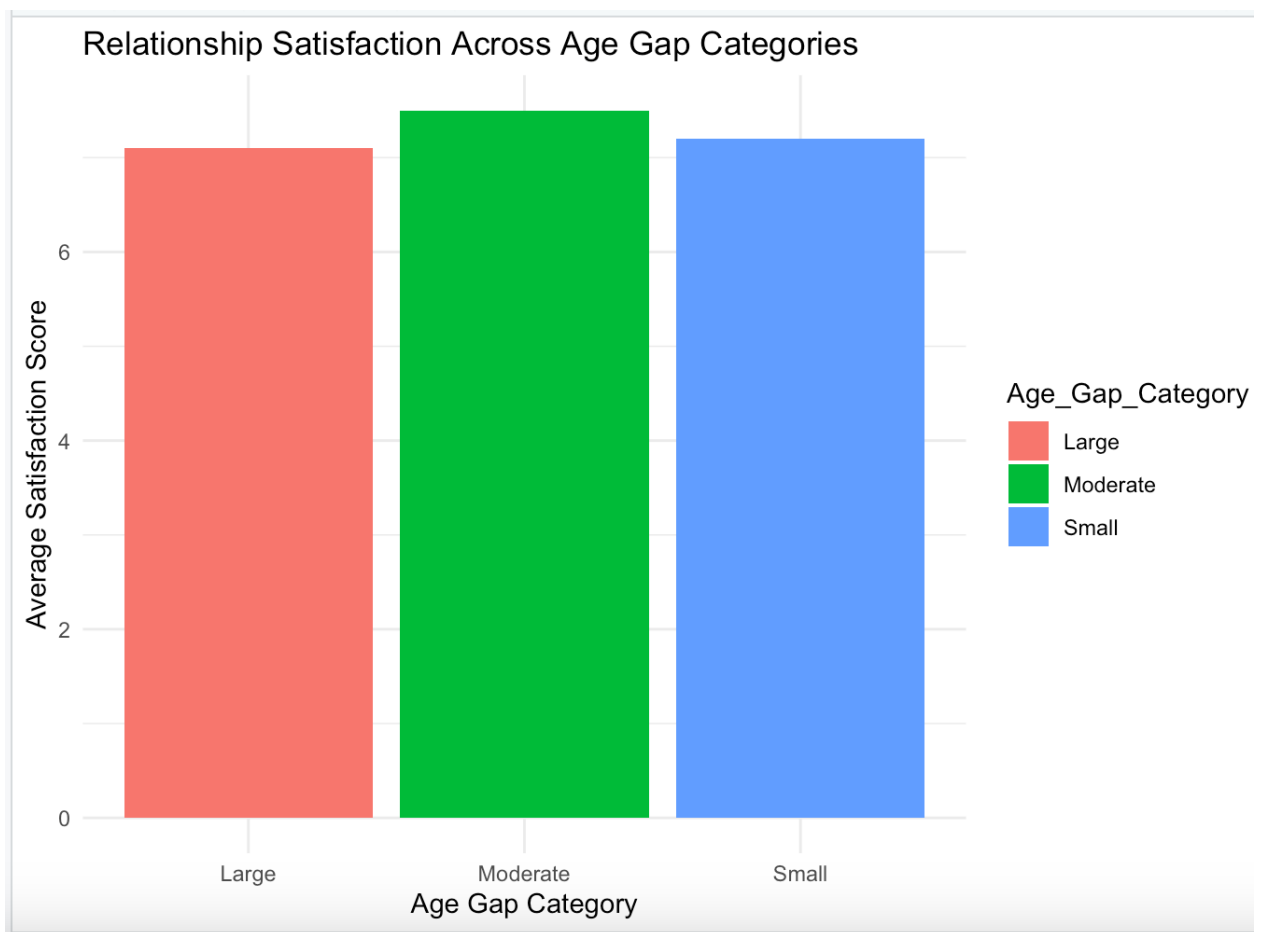


Figure 1

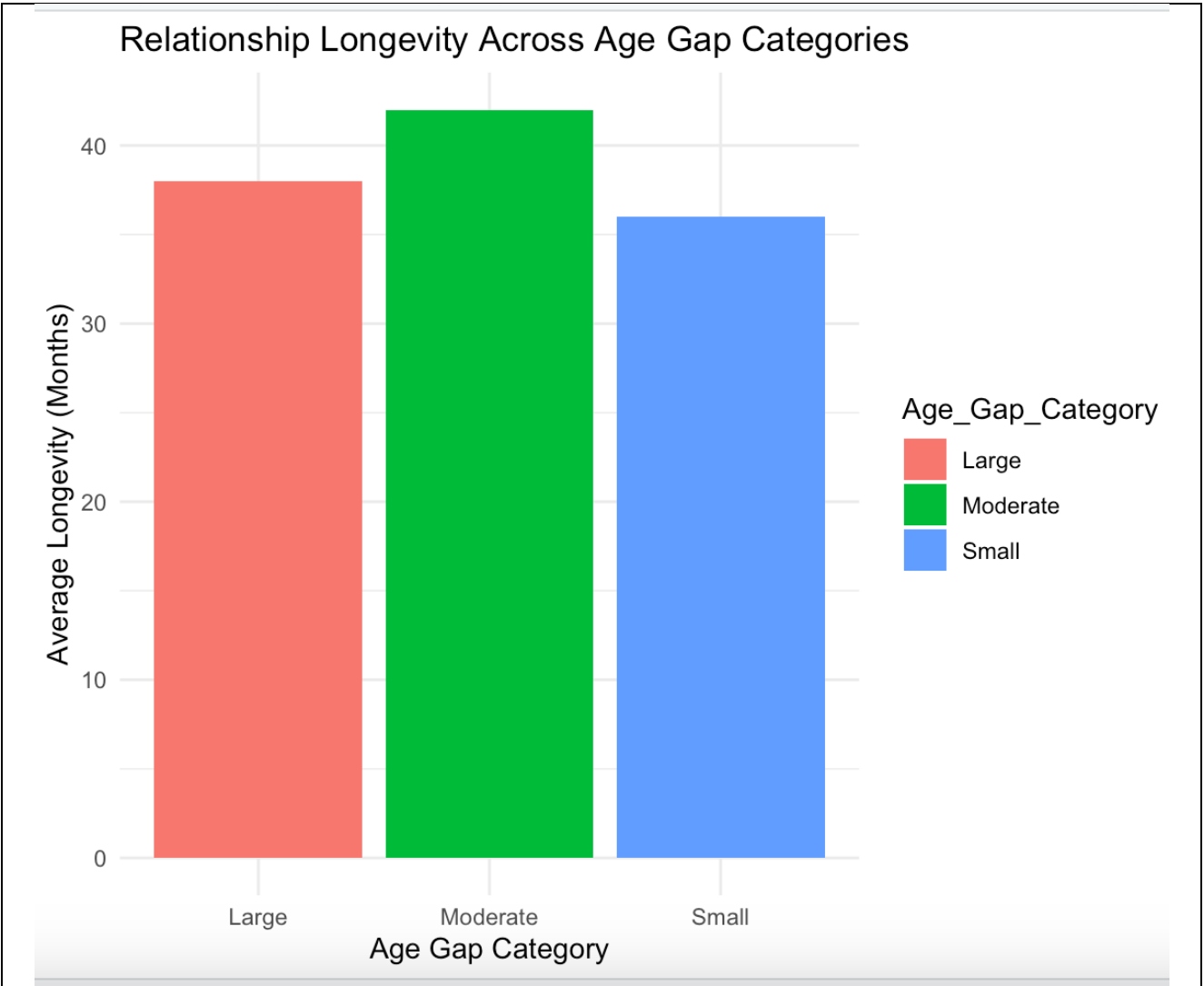


Figure 2

